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# It Pains Me to Say It, but Gavin Newsom Is on to Something Here

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# It Pains Me to Say It, but Gavin Newsom Is on to Something Here

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Gavin Newsom, it has often been observed, has a bit of a Patrick Bateman quality: He is TV-anchor handsome, is aggressively charming, and comes off as profoundly narcissistic and possibly a psychopath.

He's also one of the only Democratic leaders who seem to be accurately clocking just how immense a threat Donald Trump and his captured Republican Party are to American democracy. He has hitched his wagon to [Proposition 50](#), a measure that would redraw California's congressional districts in response to Texas' recent redistricting, which awarded more seats to the GOP. Once California voters cast their ballots, the country will get a preview of whether Newsom's muscular response to Trump is actually effective—and whether Newsom, who is considering a run in 2028, has presidential chops.

Cards on the table: [I am not a big Newsom fan](#). I can admit that my dislike of him is in large part about vibes—it's the Patrick Bateman thing. He strikes me as the kind of politician who is willing to be blown by the political winds, someone who is interested in power first and principles second, who is just a little *too* slick. But as Trump has coarsened the nation and lowered our collective standards, I guess he has lowered mine too. Newsom wouldn't be my first pick for president. But he wouldn't be the first possible psychopath, or at least major narcissist, to sit in the Oval Office—and some of these predecessors have done a pretty good job.

[A study published](#) in 2013 by a group of psychologists ranked presidents on a scale of grandiose narcissism, and a few of those at the top were indeed very bad. Andrew Jackson, [génocidaire of](#) various Native American tribes and [Trump's favorite president](#), is ranked third; Teddy Roosevelt (on the plus side, great antitrust policies; on the minus side, an enthusiastic killer of African elephants and rare rhinos) is second. Richard Nixon is sixth. But others have a more mixed record, and one can see how their bullying and narcissism might have served them. No. 1 on the list is Lyndon Baines Johnson. His demerits are significant, and they are summed up by the words *Vietnam War*. On the domestic front, however, he was the force behind the Great Society, including the creation of Medicaid and Medicare and the establishment of the Voting Rights Act and Civil Rights Acts of 1964 and 1968, all laws he was able to pass via bullying and manipulation. He also notoriously [held meetings](#) while he sat on the toilet, a move that encapsulated his crass, domineering style. No. 4 on the list is Franklin Delano Roosevelt, the president who brought us the New Deal. Coming in at No. 5 is John F. Kennedy, and No. 7 is Bill Clinton. (Hard to quibble with the narcissism designations there, even as Clinton dramatically expanded the economy and instituted SCHIP, the national children's health care program.) The list was assembled without considering Barack Obama, but I imagine he may also have ranked at least in the upper third. He's also the reason millions of Americans have access to health care.

Other psychologists have looked at presidential psychopathy [and concluded that](#) several of the characteristics associated with psychopathy (fearlessness, interpersonal dominance) may be beneficial to leadership roles, including the presidency. "Fearless dominance, for example, may contribute to reckless criminality and violence, or to skillful leadership in the face of a crisis," the study's [lead author stated](#). The presidents with the highest "fearless dominance" ranking will be

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familiar: Teddy Roosevelt, JFK, and FDR. (The most psychopathic-narcissistic presidents are apparently, like serial killers, also the ones typically known by all three of their initials.)

Gavin Christopher Newsom (GCN?) does not, to my laywoman's eye, have many of the maladaptive traits of psychopathy, such as poor impulse control ([COVID lockdown dinner at French Laundry](#) notwithstanding). He does, though, seem to meet Trump's desire for dominance head-on, in a way no other Democrat has been quite able to. And Prop 50 is testing that strategy.

The Prop 50 vote is one of the most important in the nation. It's also indicative of the democratic depletions that Trump has brought about. The proposition would alter California's congressional makeup to give Democrats an even larger advantage in the largely blue state. Redistricting efforts are usually done every decade on the decade; this modification, midway through the usual time frame and just a year before the midterm elections, is both highly unusual and a transparent effort to tip the scales in Democrats' favor.

But it's also necessary, because Republicans did it first—and in that sense, Prop 50 isn't so much tipping the scales as rebalancing them, assuming it passes. [Trump's agenda](#) is predictably unpopular, and Republicans are worried about paying the price in the 2026 midterms. But instead of adjusting the agenda to give voters what they want, [Trump has demanded](#) that leaders in conservative states change long-adhered-to electoral norms to give Republicans an advantage. Some states, most notably Texas, have done just that, redrawing congressional districts to cut Democrats out and, they hope, ensure an unearned GOP majority in the House. It's radically undemocratic, an affront to the most basic of American values: that our government is representative of the people.

Most Democrats, though, have simply hemmed and hawed, adding red-state redistricting to their long list of (justified) gripes. Newsom took action. Because of a state law put into place to safeguard against partisan gerrymandering, he couldn't simply redistrict by degree; he had to put the question to the people of California. And this week, they're deciding whether they want to potentially prevent Republican-led states from stealing a House majority—even if it means veering off the high road.

Newsom has made Prop 50 his signature issue. He's the one who called the special election to vote on the measure. He has [raised an enormous amount of money](#) in support of it. He has traveled across his state, talking to voters about why they should support it. And he has helped make the proposition a reasonable one: It would be temporary, and in 2030 California would redraw its congressional districts as usual, per the most recent census.

Newsom is also clear on the stakes. The current House, led by Speaker Mike Johnson, [has more or less ceded its power](#) to Trump. It's actually been absurd to watch the supposedly co-equal body turn into a cowering, submissive duma, the GOP majority little more than a ceremonial body, with Republicans not just letting Trump undo their decisions and votes but publicly supporting him in doing so. The president has essentially taken back money Congress appropriated, and Republicans have let him. And it's not just the House: Congress is supposed to authorize any war the U.S. embarks on; Republicans in the Senate recently [blocked a measure](#) that would have exercised their right to do just that.

The Senate, though, is an intentionally undemocratic body, with each state having two representatives no matter its population, virtually giving low-population states like Wyoming far more power than the ones where the largest numbers of Americans live. The Supreme Court, stacked with right-wing appointees, also continues to [do Trump's bidding](#). There's not much that can be

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done about that at the moment. That makes the House one of the only real checks on Trump's abuses of power. Returning it to Democratic hands in 2026 is crucial.

Trump and Newsom both understand that, which is why Trump, famous for attempting to steal an election he lost fair and square, is trying to deploy technically legal means to profoundly undemocratic ends. It makes him a bully and a cheater, but without fair refs in this particular game, there is no real recourse—other than doing the same thing, which is throwing out norms of fair play using technicalities to your advantage. This is where Newsom is one of the few Democrats actually going toe-to-toe with Trump.

On a moral level, I hate this. I wish Americans would have seen Trump piling weights on his side of the scale and lost their collective minds, taken to the streets, and made clear that there would be decadeslong consequences for all who went along with this nasty little endeavor. I wish elected Republicans had even an ounce of decency or self-respect or love for this nation left and were adult enough to tell the president, “No, I will not help you effectively cheat your way to a House majority.” I wish that the GOP would see the swelling backlash and decide to change course, not force its will on Americans.

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I want to be very high-minded about this. Nothing good comes from a race to the partisan bottom, with red and blue states alike redistricting whenever they want. But I also look back on four years of the Biden administration and realize that, even after four years of Donald Trump, Democrats utterly failed to put safeguards in place to prevent a faster and furious-er sequel.

Now we're out of good options. Our democracy is on life support. And Newsom, at least, is attempting via democratic means to keep Trump from pulling the plug.

Does that make him presidential material? I'm not sure you'll ever see me with a “Newsom 2028” button. But the man knows how to stand strong, and like many men who read to me as narcissists, he certainly knows how to grab attention. As liberal commentator Chris Hayes has [written about at length](#), attention is the world's most endangered—and possibly most valuable—resource. Trump

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knows how to grab it. So does Newsom.

The best thing the Democratic Party can do for itself in 2028 is have a real competition of candidates, ideas, and styles. The 2024 election was a campaign of obligation, followed by a campaign of anointment. There was no real hashing out of what the party is, what it prioritizes, and what it broadcasts to Americans. Next time should be different. Maybe the Democratic Party is one of articulate and erudite technocrats like Pete Buttigieg. Maybe it's a party of get-it-done moderates like Josh Shapiro. Maybe an octogenarian socialist from Vermont is the right pick. Maybe it's a coalition best led by Newsom, a San Francisco liberal who is willing to troll Trump. The party's immediate future may be held by a wide diversity of white men, from conservative Democrats to centrist ones. But we should have them compete with one another.

I am partly kidding, of course. The 2028 Democratic primary will hopefully be a rollicking one, and I pray that some leftists and women and people who are not white but who are also not Kamala Harris throw their various hats in the ring. (Gretchen Whitmer? AOC—Ayanna Pressley 2032? The list is admittedly short.) And if voters decide that what they want is someone who can capture their attention, pwn the troll in chief, and play dirty if it means saving the nation, well, I certainly won't judge. After all, voters aren't marrying the guy (we aren't Kimberly Guilfoyle). We're just putting him in charge of the free world. And, frankly, we could do worse.

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